Jeremy Lin: Evaluating Journalism's Coverage of Basketball's Asian American Star

February 4, 2012, New York City.

Madison Square Garden is packed with 19,763 fans in attendance as the New York Knicks set to face off against the New Jersey Nets. The Knicks entered this bout having lost 11 of their last 15 games, were dealing with injuries to their starting point guard, Baron Davis, and were playing the third game in a back-to-back-to-back (ESPN, 2012).

As the game began, the Knicks were exhausted and lacked a playmaker to distribute the ball. With 3:35 minutes left in the first quarter, head coach Mike D'Antoni would look to the end of the bench to sub in the third-string point guard, Jeremy Lin. It was Lin's first true opportunity, as the 23-year-old guard had only played a total of 12 minutes in the last 9 games in what is generally considered "garbage time" (The Old Man and The Three, 2022, 42:22).

However, against the Nets, what was originally a scrambling effort by the coaching staff became the start of an episode ingrained into sports culture to this day.

Whenever "Linsanity" is mentioned in sports media today, it refers to Jeremy Lin's impressive yet unexpected 2-week stint of excellence. In 2012, "Linsanity" was at the center of headlines and sports journalism, covering every corner of Lin's momentum, documenting the Taiwan-American's rise to stardom.

In this paper, I will revisit the 2012 Linsanity run to understand how sports journalism constructed narratives that emphasized Lin's identity as an Asian American athlete as much as

his on-court performance. I will argue how media coverage of Lin perpetuated historical journalistic practices of commercialization, sensationalism, and racial framing, transforming his impressive level of play into an identity-driven cultural phenomenon.

Who is Jeremy Lin?

Jeremy Lin credits his passion for basketball to his father, Gie-Ming Lin, who introduced Jeremy to the sport. In high school, Lin played for Palo Alto High School and led the school to a California State championship, earning California Player of the Year honors. From his earliest days of playing basketball, Lin not only faced tough competition but also constant stereotyping and being overlooked (Chi, 2022).

Despite his accomplishments, Lin received no Division I offers. Lin eventually played for Harvard, studying economics despite not receiving an athletic scholarship. Lin received multiple All-Ivy League Honors at Harvard but was not drafted by any NBA team. According to Lin in 2022, on pre-draft analyses, “what they would say on paper was what you would say about any Asian” (Chi, 2022).

The Golden State Warriors would take a chance on Lin, as owner Joe Lacob had watched him play against his son, despite the head coach and general manager having no desire for Lin to be on the team. The Warriors would cut Lin shortly after. Lin had been picked up by the Houston Rockets before being cut by them as well. Jeremy Lin continued to be overlooked, a position he was all too familiar with (Chi, 2022).

Finally, the Knicks would give Lin a non-guaranteed rookie contract. With Lin's uncertainty of staying on the roster, the 23-year-old would sleep on his brother's couch for six weeks. In a game against the New Jersey Nets, Linsanity was born. Lin, a relatively unknown player who sat at the end of the bench, checked into the game scoring 25 points and 7 seven assists. This high level of play continued for another 25 games, and the stint was remembered as "Linsanity."

Commercialization

Following the game against the New Jersey Nets, Jeremy Lin created a greater demand for coverage as Linsanity continued. With the New York Knicks being a large-market franchise, Lin's success brought even more eyes to the team, leading to even more media attention. Lin's popularity was international, capturing the attention of sports fans worldwide. In a 2026 podcast, former teammate Iman Shumpert recalls, "the media [Lin] used to bring around could barely speak English…they used to fly in from everywhere…China, Taiwan, just flooding in from everywhere" (Out The Mud, 2026, 1:04:34)

At the peak of Linsanity, Lin's jersey was the second-highest-selling in the NBA (CNBC, 2012)

The name "Linsanity" was a marketable brand that could be plastered across headlines in newspapers, on social media, and in broadcasts. Publications such as Sports Illustrated, New York Post, and WBEZ Chicago would feature Lin on many of their covers. Most famously,

Jeremy Lin is pictured on the cover of TIME Magazine, an example of how Lin transcended sports media and captured national news attention.

In a podcast with then-coach Mike D'Antoni, he recalls, "we would go to practice, and they had 80 media people there…they had two rooms, a print room and a video room, and not only would you have your normal sports writers but Wall Street Journal, CNN, the E show…it was unbelievable" (Old Man and The Three, 2022, 41:20).

Many of these headlines would invite readers to learn about Lin's true underdog beginnings and continue to emphasize his unexpected rise. In TIME magazine's coverage, they reiterate how, "as a high school prospect, Lin never got such love from college coaches, who couldn't imagine the pencil-necked point guard expanding his razor-thin frame" (TIME Magazine, 2012) The article transitions to how Lin's success has shaped a culture of Asian-American basketball fans who can cheer for an athlete of their racial background.

In the 19th century, the penny press was a dominant form of media, marking a transition from elite political news to human-interest stories designed to generate revenue. Stories during this commercialized period covered the events and the lives of ordinary individuals, as well as marriages and couples. The penny press enforced the idea that "news emerges as a product and readers as commodities" (Chadha, 2026). In that same vein, journalists covered Lin's success as he was an international sensation. The media would cover Lin's career prior to Linsanity and share his underdog narrative, which could resonate with readers and fellow Asian-Americans. Lin was truly one of the most instant "human-interest stories" in sports.

Sensationalism

Journalists and sports media not only told Lin's narrative, but also developed their own stories surrounding the point guard.

As intermediaries between athletes and the general public, sports journalists often have the power to shape narratives and fuel excitement for teams or players. In the midst of Linsanity, Lin and the Knicks were set to face the Los Angeles Lakers and Kobe Bryant on the 10th of February. Bryant had won two back-to-back championships only two years prior and looked to bring the Lakers back to the winning caliber. Lin had just come off three 20+ point victories and was about to face off against one of the league's best (ESPN, 2012).

It is extremely common for sports reporters and media to develop storylines between athletes (University of Kentucky, 2023). With Lin's recent success and Bryant's notoriety as an all-time great, journalists began constructing a rivalry between the two players.

After a win against the Boston Celtics on February 9th, Bryant's post-game interview centered around his next game against the New York Knicks and Lin's gameplay in the past week. The reporters deliberately framed their questions to elicit a response from Bryant and to record his opinion on Jeremy Lin. Questions such as, "Are you surprised at the production that Lin's had over the past week?" and "Would you consider guarding him if he's having one of those games?"

These questions prompt Bryant to respond, “I don’t even know what he’s done, I have no idea what you guys are talking about,” and “Jesus Christ, let's not get ahead of ourselves” (Chi, 2022) These answers immediately unfolded into headlines with ESPN titling their story, “Kobe on Lin: 'I don't know what he's done” (ESPN, 2012).

In the 2022 documentary “38 At The Garden,” Lin recalls seeing these quotes before the February 10 faceoff and being motivated by them. Lin stated how he told himself he would be “hella aggressive” in his game plan against Bryant and the Lakers (Chi, 2022). This emphasis on drama not only generated excitement among readers and fans but also affected the players themselves.

Through secondary sources, it can be exemplified how journalism’s ability to create its own narrative and sensationalize relationships between players affected Lin’s mindset, effectively working to his benefit as Lin went on to score 38 points in an electrifying victory over the Lakers (ESPN, 2012).

Racial Framing

In the 26-game stretch of Linsanity, Jeremy Lin averaged 18.5 points, 7.7 assists, and 3.7 rebounds per game (Statmuse). Lin excited crowds with his flashy assist and crafty athleticism, getting to the rim. Even with his high level of play, Lin’s identity as a Taiwanese-American athlete in the NBA was in constant discussion.

As of 2025, only 0.8% of NBA players are of Asian descent (Gaetano et al., 2025). As a minority in a global field, coverage of Lin's race presents a contrast between positive representation and racism.

Many publications covering Lin gave their Asian American journalists the opportunity to cover the rising star. The decision to avoid objectivity when journalists have personal connections to the subject at hand yielded stories that better explain different angles of Lin's impact beyond basketball.

For Michael Luo of the New York Times in his 2012 article, "Lin's Appeal: Faith, Pride and Points," he writes, "The feelings the Lin phenomenon instills in me are orders of magnitude greater because he is an Asian-American, like me, whose parents were immigrants to this country, like mine. He grew up, like me, in the United States, speaking English; his Chinese, like mine, could use improvement" (Luo, 2012). Luo explains how he resonated with the basketball star and felt true representation when someone from a similar upbringing received "MVP" chants at the highest level.

Chuck Leung, another Asian American journalist, offered another perspective on Lin's representation in the Asian community. In his article titled "Lin-Glorious Bastards" for Slate Magazine, Leung opens the article by writing how he, like Luo, naturally gravitated towards Lin. Both Leung and Jeremy Lin were Asian, undersized high school athletes, and studied economics in college. However, Leung described himself as "Lin-secure," worrying that Lin's success "will validate and reinforce familiar stereotypes of 'Asian-ness': the hard work, the humility, the

studiousness, even the Christian faith" (Leung, 2012). Due to the commercialized coverage of Lin's story as a humble, intelligent Harvard graduate, Leung feared that Lin would reinforce Asian stereotypes.

With this mindset, Leung comments that he had hoped Lin would improve the standard for masculinity among Asian American males. However, he ends the article reflecting on how these feelings stem from the novelty of seeing someone like him on the big stage. Leung concluded by noting that it can be extremely easy to ask too much of our heroes, and that this level of representation should not be clouded by close-minded judgments.

Although many journalists applauded Lin for his ability to be a beacon of representation and inspiration for Asian Americans, Lin's identity as a Taiwanese American gave room to microaggressions and blatant racism in journalism.

In an article published by The Atlantic on February 14, 2012, Robert Wright writes, "The Secret of Jeremy Lin's Success?" The subtitle of this piece seemingly answers the question posed by the title, stating, "How the New York Knick's philosophical heritage may be helping him win" (Wright, 2012). The article goes into mentioning the oddities of an Asian American basketball player being extremely successful, with "philosophical heritage" being a jab at Asian cultures of worship.

Following Lin's 38-point victory over the Lakers, Fox Sports columnist Jason Whitlock tweeted out, "Some lucky lady in NYC is gonna feel a couple inches of pain tonight." This misogynistic

and racist comment by Whitlock brought about backlash for the columnist, prompting Whitlock to issue an apology two days later. Whitlock stated that his tweet was a “joke” from his “sophomoric, comedic nature” and how he still desires to be a stand-up comedian (CBS, 2012).

One of the most recognizable moments of racism during Linsanity was the headline published by ESPN titled, “Chink in the Armor.” After the first loss in the Linsanity era to the New Orleans Hornets on February 16, 2012, editor Anthony Federico titled the game recap with a slur targeting Chinese Americans. ESPN immediately fired Federico and issued an apology after taking down the headline (CNN, 2012).

These examples demonstrate how language used to cover the first Asian American basketball star held racialized implications and questioned professional journalistic standards in sports media. Even with the use of slurs and microaggressions, the balance of portraying Lin as a mode of inspiration as opposed to a target for anti-Asian remarks was reflective of journalistic framing throughout the 2012 stretch of games.

Conclusion

In the decade following Linsanity, Jeremy Lin went on to complete a 9-season career in the NBA and win a championship with the Toronto Raptors in 2019. As of today, Lin serves as a basketball analyst for the New York Knicks post-season finals run.

Looking back on Linsanity and its relationship with the media, journalists and publications recognized the attention Lin garnered, and they understood that sharing his humble upbringing could appeal to readers. As his success mounted, the media constructed narratives surrounding Lin and developing rivalries between stars such as Kobe Bryant, effectively raising excitement for the game and fueling Lin for a historic performance. As a Taiwanese-American athlete, Lin represented a broad Asian-American community, as told through sports journalists. On the other hand, Lin faced racist remarks by publications that looked to capitalize on his performance. Linsanity was an era in sports media that demonstrated how commercialization, sensationalism, and racial framing turned a spurt of basketball excellence into a narrative-driven analysis of Lin's identity, ultimately forming the cultural phenomenon that lives on to this day.

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